

## Surge in flu season sickness a reminder of alternative healthcare options for non-urgent cases

The health system is experiencing a significant increase in winter illness, with the peak expected to continue for several more weeks.

Over the past week, community and primary care, Healthline, ambulance services, emergency departments and hospitals have experienced a significant surge in winter illness cases.

Health NZ Chief Executive Dr Dale Bramley is encouraging people to reserve emergency departments for emergencies, while emphasising that anyone experiencing an emergency should seek immediate care.

“We are here when people need us, and we have also invested in many other ways of supporting people to get the right care they need. If you don't need emergency care, using these other options will help our ED teams around the country focus on those who need their expert care the most.”

Winter planning began at the start of the year, with a \$25 million Winter Plan investment that includes:

- several hundred additional full-time-equivalent staff
- 71 additional hospital beds planned, with 103 delivered to date and a further 163 flexible beds available
- hundreds of additional aged residential care placements across the country

Health NZ Executive National Director - Clinical Dr Richard Sullivan says people with non-urgent needs can access convenient and timely care through community pharmacies, Healthline and online GP services, helping general practices and EDs remain available for people with more urgent and complex needs.

Pharmacies and online GP services can provide fast access to care for a range of common conditions, while the free Healthline phone service can help people decide the best course of action.

In June, Health NZ expanded the range of funded clinical services available through community pharmacies, building on their role as a trusted and accessible first point of contact for advice and treatment.

More than 32,000 people have visited participating pharmacies since the service launched, with 26,208 consultations completed. Pharmacy participation is at 81 per cent, with 896 pharmacies nationwide offering the extended service.

Participating pharmacists can provide health advice and treatment for common conditions, including supplying some antibiotics, emergency contraceptives and pain medication where appropriate.

Online GP services are also experiencing strong uptake. Since launching in May 2025, the service has provided 115,426 consultations for 85,784 people, with 87 per cent of patients treated online at the time. Children aged 14 and under have been able to access the service free of charge since the start of August.

The online service is available from home and through a growing network of health providers. Funding has been provided to 247 pharmacies and 56 urgent-care clinics, rural hospitals and health centres to install infrastructure so people can use the service on site.

Whakarongorau Telehealth has seen a 7.4 per cent increase in average daily calls, with total demand rising to 9,990 from 9,299. At Health NZ's request, additional staff have been rostered to maintain responsiveness and meet weekend demand.

Trained non-clinical staff are now managing callers seeking information and service navigation, enabling an additional 200 calls to be answered over the past three days. Calls about young children are being redirected to PlunketLine, where additional nursing staff have answered around 200 more calls.

**Emergency care:** Anyone needing emergency care should go to an emergency department without delay or call 111. Emergency departments remain open 24 hours a day, seven days a week.

It is not too late to receive a winter flu vaccination, which is free for eligible people.